

The 6:15

MONDAY · AUGUST 17, 2026

NO. 4

THE BOARD

CALENDAR — NEXT 10 DAYS

Tue Aug 18	Home Depot (HD) earnings, premkt — cons. EPS \$4.71; Alaska & Florida primaries
Wed Aug 19	FOMC July minutes; Target (TGT) premkt — cons. EPS ~\$2.25–2.32, rev ~\$26.1B; Lowe's (LOW) premkt — cons. EPS \$4.22–4.25; TJX premkt — cons. EPS \$1.18–1.19; Wyoming primary
Thu Aug 20	Walmart (WMT) premkt — cons. EPS \$0.73–0.74, rev ~\$186.7B; Deere (DE), Ross Stores (ROST); jobless claims
Wed Aug 26	Nvidia (NVDA) aft. close — rev cons. ~\$91–95B; Salesforce, CrowdStrike, aft. close; July PCE price index, Q2 GDP (2nd est.), durable goods, 8:30a (BEA)
Thu Aug 27	Marvell (MRVL) aft. close; jobless claims; Jackson Hole symposium opens through 8/29 — Fed Chair Warsh keynote Fri 8/28
Tue Sep 16	Next FOMC decision

OPEC+: 67th JMMC met 8/2 (past); 68th JMMC not until 10/4, outside this window. Treasury: routine bill rolls only in this window; no coupon (note/bond) auction confirmed. Lighter days 8/21–8/25 omitted for space; Intuit and Dick's Sporting Goods report Tue 8/25.

METRICS · ~6:25A ET AUG 17 UNLESS NOTED

Brent / WTI / spread	\$89.46 (+1.06%) / \$82.20–83.02 (unreconciled) / \$6.42–7.26 — Investing.com/TradingEconomics
UST 2y / 10y / 30y	3.98% / 4.51% / 5.25% (Treasury.gov, Fri 8/14 close — live quotes run ~15–20bp higher, unreconciled)
DXY	99.43 (–0.24%)
S&P / Nasdaq-100 futures	+0.14% / +0.51% (premarket, delayed data)
VIX	14.25 (Fri cash close, –2.60%; Mon not yet available; Sep futures ~15.6–15.7)
Gold (spot)	\$4,394.60 (+0.43%) — Kitco, 6:26a ET

Nikkei / Hang Seng	69,194.00 +0.70% (Mon close) / 25,453.23 +1.34% (Mon close)
DAX / FTSE / CAC	26,441.05 +0.03% / 10,749.21 -0.01% / 8,622.86 -0.16% (live, still trading)
Retail gas, natl. avg.	\$4.0636/gal (AAA, 8/17)

WTI: front-month rolled Sep → Oct on 8/16; two aggregators differ by ~\$0.80, unresolved.
 Treasury: Treasury.gov's official Friday close runs 15–20bp below live secondary 2y/10y quotes; 30y roughly agrees. Neither gap resolved this run.

HORMUZ COUNTERS

Closure	Day 169 (straits.live, 10:24 UTC 8/17)
Transits vs. baseline	1 vessel 8/9 vs. 73/day pre-crisis (PortWatch AIS, 8-day lag)
Weekly transits	78, wk 8/3–8/9, down 18% from 95 (Lloyd's List); non-Iranian-linked 45, down 29% from 63
Weekend transits	5 vessels Sat 8/15, zero Sun 8/16 — vs. 31 the prior weekend (CNBC)
Strikes, 24–72h	3 ADNOC-affiliated tankers struck 8/14–15; bulk carrier hit by unidentified projectile near Kumzar, Oman, 8/15–16 (UKMTO/WAM)
Strikes, cumulative	~56 (UKMTO, pre-dates this week) / ~61 (secondary aggregation) / ~65, 17 killed (IMO-attributed via press pickup) (three figures, not netted)
Dark tankers	92, 24h, vs. 51.5 7-day avg. (straits.live)
War-risk premium	30.0× pre-crisis; ~\$10.0M/VLCC passage (straits.live, last updated ~8/5 — stale)

PortWatch counts AIS vessel movements with a multi-day lag; Lloyd's List aggregates weekly commercial transits >10,000 dwt with Iran-link attribution, preliminary and revised weekly; straits.live blends broker war-risk quotes with dark-ship detection at varying refresh rates. Three different universes — don't average or net them against each other.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees / Knicks / Northwestern	No reported roster moves in the last 24 hours (Josh Hart's extension, eligible since 8/10, still unsigned)
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LEAD

HORMUZ · TERRITORIAL CLAIM

Trump vows to make the Strait of Hormuz “a territory of the United States”; weekend transits hit zero for the first time this war.

President Trump said Friday he intends to declare the Strait of Hormuz “a territory of the United States” once Iran is “defeated,” telling reporters it would happen “pretty soon” — an escalation from the “100% Navy control” language he used two weeks ago to something closer to outright annexation. Iran’s response was uniform across factions that otherwise agree on little: Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi said the strait “cannot be seized by tweet, nor by aircraft carrier, nor by issuing an order, nor by an election speech” and “has been Iranian, is Iranian, and will remain Iranian”; the judiciary chief called the claim the “delusions of a feeble-minded individual”; Parliament Speaker Ghalibaf said separately Sunday that Iran “truly won this war both militarily and politically.” *(Read: the uniformity of the rebuttal, across power centers that don’t usually agree, suggests Trump handed Tehran a unifying line at a moment its own economy is visibly struggling — President Pezeshkian said this weekend, “we used to sell oil, but now we cannot sell it.”)*

The rhetoric landed alongside the worst run of actual shipping attacks since the ceasefire MoU collapsed in July. Three separate ADNOC-affiliated tankers were struck Thursday and Friday, and a bulk carrier was hit by an unidentified projectile near Kumzar, Oman, over the weekend; UAE’s Foreign Ministry called the ADNOC strikes a “flagrant violation” of international law. The concentration of hits on a single state oil company’s fleet, rather than the more diffuse targeting of prior months, reads as a deliberate signal aimed at the UAE specifically — a U.S.-aligned Gulf state

that has stayed rhetorically firm but hadn't previously taken the brunt of Iranian retaliation.

The transit numbers confirm the deterioration. IMF/Oxford PortWatch's satellite tracking, which lags roughly a week, showed a single vessel transiting on Aug. 9 against a ~73/day pre-war baseline; Lloyd's List's fresher weekly count (through Aug. 9) showed total transits down 18% week-on-week to 78, with non-Iranian-linked traffic down 29%. Then came the clearest number yet: 5 vessels transited Saturday and zero Sunday, against 31 the weekend before. Zero is a reading this war hadn't produced before, even at its worst prior stretches.

Oil is pricing the deterioration, not the rhetoric. Brent settled Friday at \$88.52 (+1.7%) and is bid to \$89.46 (+1.06%) in early trading (Investing.com, 6:18a ET) — up roughly \$5 from two Mondays ago and pushing back toward the year's highs, though still short of them. WTI is harder to read cleanly this morning: the front-month contract rolled from September to October on Friday, and the two aggregators we checked disagree by nearly a dollar on the resulting level (~\$82.20 vs. ~\$83.02) — treat the exact print as unsettled until the roll clears.

Equities are mostly shrugging it off on the surface: S&P futures are bid toward 7,815.75 this morning, building on a week that produced back-to-back record closes (7,748.50 Wed 8/12, then 7,798.99 Thu 8/13) even as retail sales and consumer sentiment both missed hard the same week. *(Read: a familiar 2026 pattern — the market treats growth-scare data softness as Fed-friendly rather than economy-worrying, so long as it doesn't show up in earnings.)* Energy is the one place the strait crisis is visibly showing up in index-level pricing

— the calm-index-real-rotation-underneath split we’ve flagged in prior issues.

The Fed angle is where this converges with last week’s data. July CPI already showed energy up 14.7% year-on-year even as headline and core landed in line with consensus; a sustained push back toward \$90 Brent sets up a bigger energy contribution in the August print, due mid-September. That arrives into a Fed conversation that had, until Thursday, been moving the other way — September hike odds on CME FedWatch roughly halved, from ~60% on Aug. 11 to an estimated 31–33% by Aug. 14, as a weak July payrolls number was reinforced by a surprise 0.6% drop in July retail sales and a University of Michigan sentiment reading that cratered to 51.0 from 55.2. Whether a renewed oil shock outweighs two soft activity prints is the live question heading into Fed Chair Kevin Warsh’s first Jackson Hole keynote on Aug. 28 — itself now shadowed by the Aug. 26 deadline Trump has set Fed Governor Lisa Cook to respond to a renewed termination effort. (*Developing.*)

POLITICS

The funding standoff that avoided an October shutdown scare is still unresolved five days later. The Senate’s 90-6 bill funds the government through Dec. 11; the House’s own July 21 version (220-205) only runs through Dec. 4 — a gap neither chamber has moved to close, since the House remains in recess and isn’t expected back until “the first week of September.” Separately, the White House reopened its effort to remove Fed Governor Lisa Cook: a letter dated Aug. 5 from Deputy Chief of Staff Dan Scavino cites the same mortgage-fraud allegations behind the first, Supreme-Court-blocked attempt, and gives Cook until Aug. 26 to respond before Trump says

he'll make a "final decision." That deadline lands one day before Fed Chair Kevin Warsh's first Jackson Hole keynote as chair — a Fed-independence storyline now running directly alongside the rate-path debate rather than beside it. Cook, a Biden appointee usually read as dovish, said in Alaska last week that inflation is "too high" and she's "prepared to act," worth noting given the composition fight underway. The Senate's CR carries a few provisions worth flagging beyond the topline date: it blocks a White House rule that would have given political appointees more control over federal grant reviews, blocks a proposed shift of funds toward Border Patrol, and rejects a \$1B request tied to Trump's proposed new class of battleships — all points of friction the House version doesn't address the same way, which is part of why reconciliation hasn't been a quick formality.

ECONOMICS

July's data landed mixed but net-dovish. CPI printed in line with consensus — headline +0.1% month-on-month/+3.4% year-on-year, core +0.2%/+2.5% (BLS, Aug. 12) — with energy the standout line: -1.5% MoM but +14.7% YoY (gasoline +24.6% YoY) as the Hormuz-driven oil premium works through. PPI followed Thursday flat on the headline (final demand unchanged MoM, +4.7% YoY unadjusted) but core PPI (ex-food/energy/trade) accelerated to +0.4% MoM from +0.1% in June, a divergence worth flagging for any pass-through to core PCE. Friday brought the two prints that actually moved the market: retail sales fell 0.6% MoM, the first drop in nine months and the sharpest in over a year, with the GDP-relevant control group down 0.4% — its first negative print since September 2025; and preliminary University of Michigan sentiment cratered to 51.0 from July's 55.2, well below the 54.5 consensus,

with one-year inflation expectations ticking up to 4.3%. Net effect: September FOMC hike odds on CME FedWatch fell from roughly 60% on Aug. 11 to an estimated 31–33% by Aug. 14 **(no clean Aug. 17 snapshot confirmed this run)**. Initial jobless claims ticked up to 209,000 for the week ended Aug. 8 versus 202,000 consensus, extending the softer-labor-market thread from July’s payrolls miss. Next data of consequence: FOMC minutes Wednesday, then a heavy Aug. 26 cluster — PCE, Q2 GDP second estimate, durable goods — landing the same day as Nvidia’s earnings.

BUSINESS

Three of last week’s most-watched prints came back split. CoreWeave beat Tuesday evening — \$2.575B revenue (+112% YoY) against \$2.56B consensus, a GAAP loss of \$1.14/share, and a backlog that grew to roughly \$104B (+246% YoY) with more than \$25B in net-new commitments added “early Q3” — and the stock jumped 19.5% the next day. Cisco beat on both lines Wednesday (non-GAAP EPS \$1.22 vs. \$1.17 consensus; revenue \$17.25B vs. ~\$16.83B) and raised its FY27 revenue guide to \$72.2–73.4B while lifting AI-hyperscaler order guidance 80% to \$9.3B for the year — and still fell 8.4% Thursday, with Piper Sandler flagging margin pressure and a conservative near-term guide. Applied Materials posted record revenue (\$9.115B, +25% YoY) and a fifth straight EPS beat (\$3.50 non-GAAP) but missed the revenue consensus slightly and fell roughly 5%. The pattern across all three: beats aren’t clearing an elevated bar. Away from earnings, SpaceX closed its \$60B all-stock acquisition of Cursor-maker Anysphere on Aug. 14 — the largest startup acquisition on record, folding the coding-agent company into a new “SpaceXAI” division with access to SpaceX’s Colossus supercomputer. AMD priced its largest-ever bond deal,

\$4.75B across four tranches, partly to fund its up-to-\$5B compute commitment under the Anthropic partnership. Nvidia's \$500B AI-infrastructure financing MOU with six asset managers, announced Aug. 10, has produced no signed agreements yet — still non-binding, still worth watching once terms land. This week's earnings calendar doubles as the first real read on consumer health since Friday's retail-sales miss: Home Depot reports Tuesday (cons. EPS \$4.71), then Target, Lowe's and TJX all report Wednesday, and Walmart and Ross Stores follow Thursday. *(Read: a big-box miss this week would corroborate Friday's control-group weakness as a real spending pullback rather than a one-month blip; a beat would argue the UMich/retail-sales pair was more noise than signal.)*

TECHNOLOGY

Global semiconductor sales hit a fresh record in June — \$134.5B, +123.6% YoY per the Semiconductor Industry Association (Aug. 6 release, the newest monthly figure available) — with SIA now projecting full-year 2026 sales above \$1.5 trillion; the Americas led the regional breakdown at +160.9% YoY, ahead of Asia-Pacific (+124.4%) and China (+112.8%). Google shipped Gemini 3.7 Flash on Aug. 13, its second Flash-tier update in three weeks, while the flagship Gemini 3.5 Pro model remains delayed. *(Read: Google is keeping cadence on its mid-tier product while the top-end release slips, not signaling the flagship has been deprioritized.)* xAI shipped Grok 4.6 (Aug. 6) and a Grok Imagine image update (Aug. 8) in the same stretch — release cadence across the frontier labs remains fast even as no lab has yet clearly separated from the pack this month. Microsoft's reported plan to order 300,000-plus Maia AI chips from TSMC for 2027 delivery remains unconfirmed by either company; Microsoft's Azure Maia GM said the reported figures “don't reflect

the scale of our program” without offering a number of its own.
(Single-sourced trade reporting, unchanged since our last issue.)

GEOPOLITICS

Russia and Ukraine traded their largest exchanges in weeks. Ukraine sent roughly 600 drones at Moscow Sunday, per Mayor Sobyanin, killing one; Russia answered with ballistic missiles and drones across Kyiv overnight, sparking fires including at a landmark book market, while a separate barrage elsewhere in Ukraine killed seven. A suspected Russian drone crossed into Romanian airspace from Moldova early Sunday and was shot down by a NATO-patrol Spanish F-18 — the fourth such shootdown over Romania this year, a reminder the war's edges keep touching alliance territory without a formal incident. Xi Jinping is set to visit the U.S. for a summit with Trump on Sept. 24, the follow-up to Trump's May state visit to Beijing, with export controls and rare-earth restrictions the live friction point heading in. Jared Kushner met Egyptian President Sisi and other regional leaders Aug. 16, primarily on Gaza ceasefire implementation rather than Hormuz — a separate diplomatic track running in parallel to the Iran standoff, not obviously connected to it yet. Sudan's civil war continues grinding toward de facto partition between the army and the RSF, with 33.7M people in need of aid and 11.7M+ displaced, the largest displacement crisis globally — a standing crisis, not a new development this window, but a scale worth keeping in view. Closer to home for the desk: the 50% U.S. tariff on Canadian goods and Section 232 steel/aluminum/copper adjustments both take effect Tuesday, Aug. 19 — two days from this issue.

IRAN & HORMUZ

The technical Oman shipping-lane deal — a 60-day, fee-free arrangement splitting inbound and outbound routes — is still not the broader accord Tehran says must precede any actual reopening. Reporting Friday said only the routing map itself has been finalized; fees and security terms remain in a further round of talks, with Iran's foreign ministry explicit that the shipping-map deal is “a separate issue” from the political conditions — sanctions relief, troop withdrawal, reparations — it's still attaching to reopening. **(Qatar and Pakistan as mediators appeared in only one source this run.)** Treasury Secretary Bessent said Friday that further economic measures against Iran are coming “next week” — isolation “never... seen in the history” of the sanctions tool, he said. **(Single-sourced, one wire pickup.)** The disruption is also spreading beyond Hormuz: a Houthi attack in the Bab el-Mandeb strait killed six aboard a cargo ship on Aug. 12, the first Red Sea shipping fatalities in over a year, and a separate Indian-flagged vessel was struck and sank off Yemen, with all 14 crew rescued. One regional-press analysis framed it as “the Hormuz model moving to the Red Sea”; treat the framing as read, not fact — the underlying attack is confirmed. Cumulative vessel-strike counts since the war began now diverge meaningfully by source (see Board); we're not netting them, but note they moved up, not down, this week. Domestically, the administration's messaging on cost isn't fully unified: Trump said Friday that higher gas prices are “worth it” and he'll “never apologize” for the military campaign, press secretary Leavitt framed gas prices and a non-nuclear Iran as equal-weight priorities, while Vice President Vance called cheap gas “goal number one” — three slightly different orderings of the same trade-off from the same White House. **(CNN, single write-up; not independently cross-verified word-for-word.)** Separately, families of sailors aboard the USS Abraham

Lincoln, on a record-long deployment anchoring the U.S. naval presence, have raised conditions concerns; Trump dismissed them and said the deployment was “not nearly long enough,” while CENTCOM’s Adm. Brad Cooper called it Sunday one of the most operationally intense deployments in modern history. A relief carrier group is reportedly being sent to eventually rotate the Lincoln out — worth watching as a signal of how long Washington expects this posture to run.

SPORTS

Yankees	Beat Toronto 4-3 (10 inn., Sun 8/16) on a Ben Rice walk-off HR, salvaging the finale after dropping the first two. 69-55, 2nd AL East, 5.5 GB Tampa Bay.
Knicks	Off-season, no game. Josh Hart’s extension (eligible since 8/10) still unsigned.
Northwestern	Off-season, no game. Opener confirmed Sat 9/5, 7:00p CT vs. South Dakota State; no starting QB named, MSU transfer Aidan Chiles the presumed favorite under new OC Chip Kelly.

Continuity. Dropped as unchanged since 8/11: Khamenei’s IRGC/Basij command-reshuffle roster (now established, no further change); TSMC’s July revenue record (already reported); Nvidia’s \$500B financing MOU mechanics beyond its still-unsigned status; full Saudi-Pakistan-Turkey defense-pact terms (signed 8/7, no new developments); the Oman deal’s original route mechanics (only finalization status is new here). No issue ran 8/12–8/16; this issue covers the full gap.

Unverified figures are marked in red. Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.